



THE ORIGINAL RELIGION OF THE PERSIAN EMPIRE and perhaps PERSIANS

AN ANCIENT RELIGION AND CULTURE

the oldest monotheistic religion still alive today is Zoroastrianism, which flourished until it was overtaken

Celebration of spring

Millions of people from Asia to the Middle East celebrate the main Zoroastrian festival, *Nowruz*. In recent years *Nowruz* has enjoyed renewed popularity in some Central Asian republics that were previously part of the Soviet Union, where religion was not encouraged, and also in Afghanistan, where non-Muslim traditions used to be forbidden.



THE AVESTA

The Zoroastrian holy book is called the *Avesta*. It contains a range of different writings, but the oldest sections are thought to be written by Zoroaster (also known as Zarathustra), the prophet who founded the religion sometime between 1500 and 1000 BC.



Man dancing to celebrate Nowruz in Afghanistan.

OUT WITH THE OLD

Chaharshanbeh Souri is the first day of *Nowruz*, the holiday that celebrates the new solar year in March. It is believed to date back to 1725 BC. Bonfires are lit and people jump over them to bring good luck for the coming year.

PERSIAN RUGS

Persians regard their rugs as some other cultures regard jewelry—a luxurious display of wealth and skill and a thing of beauty. They also function as a form of savings account, which can be sold off at any time for cash if needed.

